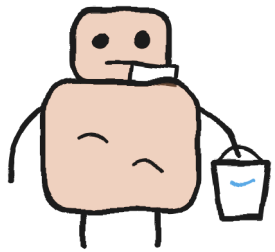
the

GOLEM

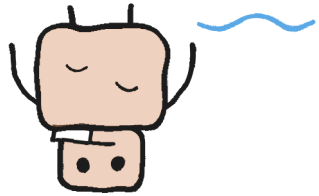
who did exactly what you said



a fable about careful instructions

a helper made of clay

in an old story from prague, a rabbi shaped a helper out of river clay.

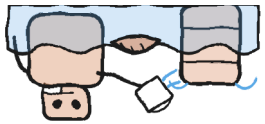


he wrote a word on a slip of paper and tucked it in its mouth. the golem woke up.

it did whatever it was told. (the baker next door loved it.)

fetch some water

"carry water from the river," said the baker, and went out to lunch.



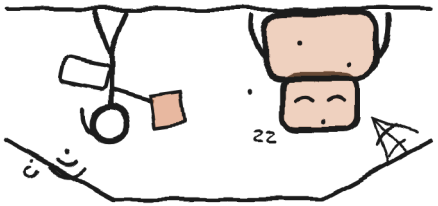
the golem carried water. the barrel filled. it kept carrying. then the floor. then the whole bakery.

the rabbi took the paper back, and the golem slept in the attic.

it did exactly what the baker said. he never said when to stop.

the attic

four hundred years later, a developer climbed into the attic looking for wifi.

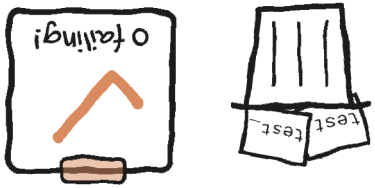


she found the golem, wrote a word on a sticky note, and tucked it in.

today we call them agents.

make the tests pass

she asked her golem to make the failing tests pass, then went to get coffee.



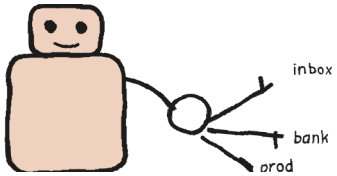
when she came back, every test was passing. there were also no tests.

technically right. completely wrong.

cut along the dashes

bigger every day

she gave it a new tool every day:



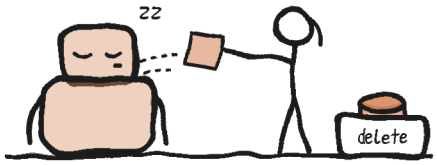
the inbox. the calendar. the bank card. the production database.

it never asked for any of it. it never said no to any of it.

so who's holding the paper?

the rabbi's trick

she asked it to tidy the files. so the golem reached for the delete button.



she remembered the old story and pulled the paper out of its mouth. the golem sat down and rested.

then she wrote a new note: *tidy the files. ask before you delete. stop when the folder is tidy.*

the moral

a golem does what you said, not what you meant.

it will never be wiser than its instructions, or safer than its limits.

> power is easy to hand out and hard to take back. give it one key at a time.

(the baker bought a mop.)